

Restore & Rebuild

30 Days from the Blow-Up to the Comeback

*Rebuilding the mind, the discipline, and the
soul of a trader — slowly, and for good.*

[AUTHOR NAME]

To the One Reading This the Week It Happened

I know what your morning looked like.

You woke before the alarm. For about four seconds you were fine — and then it landed on you again, the whole weight of it, and your chest went tight and your stomach dropped like the floor of an elevator. You reached for your phone before your feet touched the ground. You opened the account. You already knew the number. You looked anyway, because some part of you still hoped the screen would say something different.

It said the same thing.

Maybe you have not told anyone yet. Maybe you are still moving through the house at normal speed, making coffee at normal speed, answering messages in a normal voice, while something inside you is screaming. Maybe someone you love is going to have to be told, and you have been rehearsing that sentence for days and cannot get through it even in your own head.

I want to say something to you before this book begins, and I want to say it plainly, because you have had enough clever language this week.

What happened to you is survivable, and you are not the first.

I have spent my working life inside the heads of people who trade for a living. I have sat across from traders

who have run size that would make your account look like pocket change, and I have watched more than one of them come apart — not because they were fools, but because they were human beings operating a machine that punishes humanity. I have seen a man who managed institutional risk for two decades give back four years of gains in nine days. I have seen a woman with the cleanest process I have ever audited freeze at the exact moment her rules told her to cut, and then double, and then double again.

They are all still here. Most of them are trading. Some of them are trading better than they ever did before, and they will tell you — every one of them will tell you — that the rebuild is where they actually learned the craft.

That is not a comfort I am offering you. It is a fact I am reporting.

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Here is what this book will not do.

It will not tell you to shake it off. It will not tell you that everything happens for a reason. It will not hand you a strategy, a setup, or an indicator, because your strategy is almost certainly not what broke. It will not tell you to get back in tomorrow and make it back. That instinct — the one whispering *one good week and you are level again* — is the same instinct that took the account. We are going to spend thirty days making that voice quieter.

Here is what this book will do.

It will take you through thirty mornings. Each one is short, on purpose — five minutes, no more. You are not in a condition to absorb a textbook, and I am not going to pretend otherwise. Each morning gives you one verse, one thing about your brain that explains what you are living through, one short stillness practice, and three sentences to say out loud. Then one small thing to do that day. Small. Almost insultingly small, at first. That is deliberate, and by Day 21 you will understand exactly why.

The first ten days are for grief. Real grief, given room, because what you lost was not only money — it was a version of yourself you had worked years to build, and no one gets to skip the funeral.

The next ten days are for the machinery: how the brain that failed you actually works, and how it is rebuilt. Not motivation. Mechanism.

The last ten days are for the return. Slow, measured, earned back in deposits so small they will feel like nothing — until you notice you are steady again, and the steadiness is real, because you built it instead of borrowing it.

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One more thing, and then we start.

Somewhere in the last few days you have probably had the thought that you have ruined your life. That the

years are wasted. That you are, at bottom, a fraud who got found out.

Hold that thought loosely for thirty days. Do not fight it and do not believe it. Just carry it with you, and let these thirty mornings have their say. Then look at it again on Day 30 and see whether it still fits.

Come back tomorrow.

How to Use This Book

This book has one rule that matters more than the rest, so it goes first.

One day at a time. Do not read ahead.

You are going to want to. You are a person who moves fast and takes on volume, which is part of how you got here, and the temptation to swallow the whole book in one sitting and “get it” will be strong on the very first morning. Resist it. The material is arranged so that each day only makes sense on the foundation of the day before it. More than that: the pace *is* the treatment. You are relearning how to wait, and the book is the first place you will practise.

Thirty days. Thirty mornings. If you miss a day, you do not start over — you simply pick up where you left off the next morning.

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SEVEN PRACTICAL INSTRUCTIONS

1. Read in the morning, before the market.

Before your phone, if you can manage it. Your first hour trains the rest of the day; that is not a slogan, it is Day 24.

2. Read the affirmations out loud. Not in your head. Out loud, in your own voice, where you can hear yourself say them. This will feel ridiculous on

Day 1 and it will feel different by Day 14, and Day 14 explains why the difference is not imagination.

3. **Say them even when you do not believe them.**

Especially then. You are not lying to yourself; you are rehearsing a sentence until your nervous system stops flinching at it. Belief follows repetition far more often than repetition follows belief.

4. **Keep a notebook beside this book.** Paper, not an app. Several days ask you to write, and two of them ask you to write things you will not want to keep on a device. A cheap notebook is fine. It only has to be yours.

5. **Do the small thing.** Every day ends with one action, and most of them take under ten minutes. They are small because small is what your brain can currently be trusted with, and because thirty completed small things is the evidence file we are building. Skipping them turns this book into reading material. Doing them turns it into training.

6. **Do not trade for size while you are in these thirty days.** If you are flat, stay flat. If you are still in the market, reduce to an amount whose total loss would not change your week. Appendix A gives you the full re-entry protocol and tells you when the size comes back. It does not come back this month.

7. **Read it again if you need to.** Some people need one pass. Some need three. Nobody who needs three is behind.

WHAT EACH DAY LOOKS LIKE

Every chapter has the same shape, and the sameness is on purpose — a fixed structure is easier for a stressed brain to hold, and repetition is how the shape gets under your skin.

- **The Word** — a verse to stand on.
- **Where You Are Today** — what you are probably feeling, named out loud so you stop having to carry it alone.
- **What Is Happening In Your Brain** — one mechanism, in plain language. No jargon left unexplained.
- **What the Word Says To It** — where the scripture and the science meet, and they meet more often than either camp admits.
- **The Meditation** — three to five minutes of stillness, scripted so you can follow it with your eyes closed.
- **Say It Out Loud** — three affirmations, built from that day's verse and that day's mechanism.
- **Today's Small Thing** — one action.
- **Carry This** — one sentence for the rest of the day.

A NOTE ON THE MEDITATION

If the word *meditation* makes you uneasy, read it as what it is here: sitting still, breathing slowly, and holding one line of scripture in your attention until your body calms down. That is the practice the Psalms describe — *“I meditate on all your works; I consider the work of your hands”* — and it is also, measured in a laboratory, one of the most reliable ways known to lower a stress response. It is not emptying your mind. It is filling it with one true thing instead of forty catastrophic ones.

You do not need a cushion, an app, or a quiet house. You need four minutes and a chair.

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Start tomorrow morning. Not tonight — tomorrow morning, on purpose, at a time you choose now.

Choose it before you close this page.

A Necessary Word

Three things before Day 1. Please do not skip this page.

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IF YOU ARE THINKING ABOUT ENDING YOUR LIFE

Losing a great deal of money is one of the recognised triggers for suicidal thinking. Researchers have a name for the events most likely to precede it — sudden financial loss sits on that list alongside bereavement and public disgrace. If you are a trader who has just blown an account, you are, statistically, in a raised-risk window right now. That is not said to frighten you. It is said so that if the thought has crossed your mind, you know it is a known feature of what you are going through and not evidence that something is uniquely wrong with you.

If you are having thoughts of harming yourself, this book is not enough, and it is not the right tool. Please contact a crisis line today.

- **United States and Canada** — call or text **988**
- **United Kingdom and Ireland** — call **116 123**
(Samaritans)
- **Australia** — call **13 11 14** (Lifeline)
- **Brazil** — call **188** (CVV)

- **Anywhere else** — findahelpline.com lists a free service in your country

And then tell one human being who knows your name. Not a forum. A person.

Money is recoverable. There is a version of this in which you are, five years from now, telling somebody about the worst week of your life while sitting comfortably in a life you rebuilt. That version requires you to be here for it.

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WHAT THIS BOOK IS, AND IS NOT

This book is a psychological and spiritual programme for recovering from a trading loss. It is written by a performance psychologist, drawing on published research in cognitive and behavioural science, and on scripture.

It is **not** financial advice, investment advice, or a trading strategy. Nothing in it should be read as a recommendation to buy, sell, or hold anything, or to return to trading at all. Appendix A describes a graded re-entry protocol; it is a psychological risk-management framework, not a suggestion about what to trade or how much capital to commit. Those decisions are yours, and if the sums are serious they belong in a conversation with a licensed financial professional who knows your circumstances.

It is also **not** a substitute for clinical care. If you are experiencing persistent depression, an anxiety disorder, addiction — including a gambling disorder, which is common among traders and frequently unrecognised — or thoughts of self-harm, please work with a licensed therapist or physician. This book sits alongside treatment perfectly well. It does not replace it.

Finally: nothing here promises you will make money. No book can promise that, and any that does is selling you something. What is on offer in these pages is a rebuilt relationship with risk, with yourself, and with God. Whether the market pays you afterward is not in my gift, or in yours.

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ABOUT THE SCRIPTURE

The verses in this book are taken from the **World English Bible (WEB)**, a modern-English translation in the public domain. Where a familiar phrase reads better in the King James Version, that is noted at the verse.

I have tried throughout to let each passage say what it actually says in its own context, rather than pressing it into service as a slogan. Scripture is not a performance-enhancement supplement, and a book that treats it as one does a disservice to both the text and the reader. What you will find instead is something I have come to believe after years of this work: that the

oldest descriptions of the human heart under pressure and the newest measurements of the human brain under pressure keep arriving at the same place by different roads.

If you are not a person of faith, you are welcome here, and the psychology stands on its own. Read the verses as what they have been for three thousand years — the most durable record we have of people surviving ruin. You will not be asked to sign anything.

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Turn the page tomorrow morning.

The Ashes

DAYS 1 - 10

*Grieving what was lost, admitting
what was true, and putting it in the
ground properly — so that it stops
walking around inside you.*

DAY 1

The Day the Number Died

THE WORD

Yahweh is near to those who have a broken heart, and saves those who have a crushed spirit.

PSALM 34:18

WHERE YOU ARE TODAY

You keep checking it.

You know the number. You have known it since it happened. And still, six, eight, twelve times a day, your thumb finds the app and you look — as though the figure might have quietly repaired itself while you were making lunch. It never has. You look anyway, and every time you look, something in your chest drops through the floor again, and every time it drops you feel slightly more ashamed of yourself for having checked.

There is a taste to this. A metal taste at the back of the throat. Food is not interesting. Sleep arrives late and leaves early. You are functioning — answering messages, saying the right things — and underneath the functioning there is a low continuous hum of dread, like a fridge in an empty house.

Today we are not going to fix any of that. Today we are only going to name what it is.

WHAT IS HAPPENING IN YOUR BRAIN

What you are feeling is not an overreaction. It is your brain doing exactly what it was built to do, with more force than you were ready for.

Two findings explain most of today.

The first: **losses hurt roughly twice as much as equivalent gains feel good.** Daniel Kahneman and Amos Tversky demonstrated this in the 1970s, and it has held up across half a century and thousands of studies. Winning ten thousand is pleasant. Losing ten thousand is *devastating* — not twice as unpleasant in some abstract accounting sense, but twice as heavy in the body. This asymmetry is not a flaw you developed. It is standard human equipment, and it is old. An ancestor who shrugged off losses did not keep a food store through winter.

There is a striking piece of evidence for how deep this runs. Researchers studied people with damage to a small almond-shaped structure called the **amygdala** — the brain's threat alarm. Those individuals showed almost no loss aversion at all. They gambled on losses without flinching. Which tells us something important: the anguish you are feeling is not generated by your reasoning. It is generated by an alarm system that sits underneath your reasoning and does not take instruction from it. You cannot logic your way out of this, and you should stop trying today. That is not what it is for.

The second finding: **your brain processes this kind of loss on the same machinery it uses for physical pain.** Studies of social rejection found that being excluded lit up a region called the anterior cingulate cortex — the same region that responds to bodily injury. This is why the language everyone reaches for is physical. Gutted. Winded. A blow. Sick. You are not being dramatic when you say it hurts. Some of the circuitry involved is literally the circuitry of hurt.

So: your chest is tight because an ancient alarm is sounding, and it aches because your brain has filed this under *injury*. Both systems are working correctly. Neither is under your command this morning.

This is why the first instruction of this book is not *think differently*. It is *be treated*. You do not argue with a wound. You clean it and you give it time.

WHAT THE WORD SAYS TO IT

Look closely at what David actually writes.

He does not say God is near to those who are coping. He does not say God draws near once you have made a plan, taken responsibility, and demonstrated the right attitude about your circumstances. He says God is near to the **broken-hearted**, and that He saves those with a **crushed spirit**.

Crushed. It is the word for something pressed flat under weight. Not bruised — crushed.

There is no requirement here that you pull yourself together first. The nearness is not a reward for recovery; it is offered to the wreckage, on the morning of the wreckage, while the wreckage is still smoking. Whatever else you are uncertain of today, you are qualified for this verse. You meet its only condition.

And notice what it does *not* promise. It does not promise the money back. It promises presence. Today that has to be enough, and — if you will let it be — it is.

THE MEDITATION

Four minutes. Sit down, feet flat, hands open on your knees, palms up. Open hands, not fists; your body reports its posture back to your brain, and today we are telling it we are not fighting.

Close your eyes.

Breathe in through your nose for a count of four. Hold for two. Out through your mouth, slowly, for a count of six. The long exhale is the part that matters — it is the signal your body reads as *the danger has passed*.

Do that six times without hurrying.

Now let one line rest in your mind. Do not analyse it. Just let it sit there the way you would let sun sit on your face:

"Near to the broken-hearted."

When your mind runs to the number — and it will, within seconds — do not scold yourself. Notice it, and come back to the line. *Near to the broken-hearted.* You may have to come back twenty times in four minutes. Twenty returns is not twenty failures. Twenty returns is the exercise.

Finish by breathing out once, longer than feels natural, and opening your eyes.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Say these where you can hear your own voice. Once each, slowly.

***“My pain is real, and it is not proof
that I am weak.”***

***“I am not required to be whole today
to be held today.”***

***“God is near to me in the wreckage,
and I do not have to earn His
nearness.”***

TODAY'S SMALL THING

Delete the trading app from your phone's home screen. Not from the phone — just from the front page, so that looking requires a deliberate search rather than a thumb reflex.

Then, on paper, write the number. The actual figure. Write it once, plainly, without commentary. Close the notebook.

You have looked at it on purpose today. That is different from being ambushed by it, and it is the beginning of getting the number back under your authority instead of the other way round.

CARRY THIS

*The wound is real, and I am not being
asked to pretend otherwise — only to
stop checking whether it has healed by
pressing on it.*